

Data Compass Case Study

Turning 110+ Data Dimensions into Decisions Non-Technical Operators Could Act On

One-line judgement: I built Baidu's real-time merchant analytics product **0-to-1**. The hard part wasn't surfacing 110+ data dimensions — it was turning them into a decision a non-technical operator could act on.

Role & Scope

Role: Lead Product Manager

Product: Data Compass — a real-time analytics product for merchants and creators on Baidu's live-commerce platform (a £2M+ daily GMV business).

Scope: Problem framing, metric and dimension design, dashboard information architecture, decision-support workflows, adoption strategy, cross-functional delivery with data, engineering and operations.

Context

Live commerce generates a firehose of data — traffic, content, product and transaction signals, changing minute by minute. The platform already exposed a lot of it. But the people who needed it most — merchants and creators running live rooms — were **not analysts**. They could see numbers; they couldn't see *decisions*.

Problem

The problem was not *"we don't have enough data."* It was:

"I can see my numbers, but I don't know which lever to pull to sell more right now."

Raw dashboards optimise for completeness. Operators need the opposite: the few signals that change what they do in the next hour, expressed in their language, not an analyst's.

Insight

Adoption of an analytics product is not driven by how many dimensions it has — it's driven by **whether a non-technical operator can look at it and know the next action**. The metric that matters isn't "dimensions shipped"; it's "decisions made."

Strategic Decisions

1. **Design for the operator's decision, not the analyst's completeness.** I organised Data Compass around the questions merchants and creators actually ask (why did traffic/conversion move, which product/segment/time is working, what to change next) — turning 110+ traffic, content, product and transaction dimensions into operational decision support rather than a raw data dump.
2. **Real-time, because live commerce is a real-time decision loop.** In a live room, a next-hour decision is worthless if the data is a day old. The product prioritised low-latency signals operators could act on mid-broadcast.
3. **Drive adoption deliberately.** A powerful dashboard nobody opens has zero value. I treated adoption and retention among *active* operators as first-class product metrics, not vanity — reaching **90%+ adoption and 95%+ retention** among active broadcasters and operators.

Trade-offs

The core trade-off was **depth vs. legibility**. More dimensions and more granular cuts make an analytics product more powerful for an expert — and more useless for the operator it was built for. I repeatedly chose legibility: surfacing the decision-relevant signal first, keeping depth available but not in the way. The bet was that an operator who *acts* on three numbers beats one who *stares* at thirty.

Outcomes & Impact

- **110+ data dimensions** across traffic, content, product and transaction data, turned into operational decision support for non-technical merchants and creators.
- **90%+ adoption and 95%+ retention** among active broadcasters and operators — the signal that it was actually used to make decisions, not just shipped.
- Became a core piece of merchant/creator intelligence on a live-commerce platform at £2M+ daily GMV.

What I Learned

- **An analytics product's real KPI is decisions made, not dimensions shipped.** Adoption and retention among the people who must act are the honest measures.
- **Legibility is a feature.** In a data-rich category, reducing what a user has to read is often more valuable than adding what they *could* read.
- **Meet non-technical users in their language.** The same data becomes a different product depending on whether it's framed as an analyst's report or an operator's next move.